

1928 DISCOVERY OF PENICILLIN

Scottish scientist Alexander Fleming discovered a mold that could destroy harmful *Staphylococcus* bacteria on unwashed petri dishes in his laboratory. Fleming realized that the mold was producing an antibacterial substance, which he named penicillin. It eventually proved a successful antibiotic, able to tackle a range of infections and diseases caused by bacteria. By 1944, chemical plants were mass-producing penicillin to supply armed forces. Today, penicillin is still one of the most widely used antibiotics in the world.

“One sometimes finds what one is not looking for.”

Alexander Fleming

Alexander Fleming
in his laboratory



Weather balloon with a radiosonde attached

1929

First radiosonde flight

French scientist Robert Bureau invented a device called a radiosonde—a small, battery-powered pack of scientific instruments, which flies suspended under a weather balloon. As a radiosonde rises through the atmosphere, it signals back useful data on air pressure and temperature. This invention was a key step in our understanding of weather.

1930

 In 1928, a newly invented plug-in heart pacemaker (an electronic device to drive the heart) revived a stillborn baby in Sydney, Australia.

1929

Van de Graaff generator

This device was invented by American scientist Robert J. Van de Graaff to create high voltages of electricity to power early particle accelerators (machines in which atomic particles are speeded up and collide with one another). Smaller versions of the generator are used to demonstrate static electricity and are used as a teaching aid.

Static electricity
makes the person's
hair stand on end.

Metal dome
collects electric charge and
transfers it to the person's
hand when touched.

1928

The Cori Cycle

Czech biochemists Carl and Gerty Cori discovered a biological cycle in which glucose breaks down into lactic acid when muscles work hard. This acid is recycled by the liver and returns to the muscles as a substance called glycogen, which is converted to glucose. This became known as the Cori, or Lactic acid, cycle.

